

Recession ending

With the global recession categorised as 'ending' by the Federal reserve and the World Bank, recruitments are expected to increase in the months to come

PHP

For a better understanding of PHP, read January 2009 issue of Fast Track

WEB TECHNOLOGIES YOU NEED TO BE AWARE OF

It is unlikely that you haven't heard of Flash and Silverlight by now. They are plug-ins for web browsers which allow rich media content in webpages. If properly used they can add a greater level of interactivity to your website and give people a richer experience of the web. If done wrong, they can as easily spell disaster (who hasn't found Flash intro-pages annoying!)

Flash might perhaps be most popular as method of embedding video content in webpages, while Silverlight's mightiest claim to fame is that it is a Microsoft technology.

Flash is a powerful tool for creating rich multimedia content. Adobe's Flex SDK however also turns it into an immensely powerful tool for creating RIAs (Rich Internet Applications). Even better the Flex SDK is free and open source! Although Adobe's Flex Builder IDE for creating Flex

applications is not free, there are many free tools which can use the SDK to create content. Using Adobe AIR SDK, you can also take your Flash applications to the desktop, and enable users to install them on their computers like regular software applications.

Silverlight is Microsoft's answer to Flash, however till v3 it had remained a weak answer indeed. As of version 3, Silverlight is capable of creating content equivalent to Flash. Microsoft provides the Silverlight SDK for free, and combined with free Eclipse tools you can get started with Silverlight too, at zero cost. For a professional environment you can use Microsoft Expression Blend which is part of the Expression Studio suite. Silverlight v2 onwards uses .NET languages for programming, which is another useful skill set applicable to multiple domains.

PHP

Possibly *the* most popular server-side scripting language for the web, and free and open source. If you have decided to get into web development, it is a good idea to know this even if you choose another language to develop in.

SQL

SQL (Structured Query Language) is not a programming language, but rather a language for describing how to access data from a database. Since any dynamic website you make will in most likelihood require a database back-end, it is necessary that you learn how to query the data and manipulate it using SQL.

ASP.NET

A successor to Microsoft's older Active Server Pages, ASP.NET is another popular server-side scripting language. It allows you to use any .NET language to code your web applications. If you're already planning to develop on .NET, this will be just an HTML throw away.

JSP

JavaServer Pages use Java as the server-side scripting language to make websites dynamic. If you already know or plan to learn Java, then you should add on this one for good measure.

Coldfusion

While Coldfusion is not nearly as popular as some of the other options listed here, it is still very much in use in intranets of some enterprises. It has a rather expensive server, however it has enough free learning resources to get you started, and a free developer version of Coldfusion is available

for testing your applications.

Perl

The Perl language has some of the most powerful features for manipulating text strings, making it a powerful language for the internet, which is essentially described in HTML text. Most paid hosting providers nowadays support Perl as a server side language. The popular Movable Type Blogging platform / CMS is in fact written in Perl.

Python

Python is becoming increasingly popular as a

Programming is something that gazillions of open source developers find rewarding enough to do for free!

server-side language for websites. It is in fact the language of choice if you wish to build applications which will run on the "Google App Engine" cloud computing service.

Developing... mobile applications

By developing applications for mobiles, you have the capability to reach into millions of pockets. Mobiles reach a different audience than personal computers as they may be used even by people who are not computer savvy, or in fact those who don't use computers at all. While this is not much of a consideration while choosing what programming language to develop on, it does mean you need to take a different approach.

Unlike PCs, where you can write software using the same programming language for any OS, mobiles tend to be a little more picky. If you want to write native applications

for mobiles, almost every OS will require you to learn a new language!

Java

Even some of the lower end mobile phone out there today support Java applications, ensuring that any Java application you write will reach the maximum audience.

Applications for Android are also written in Java; however the dialect is a little different. Java's presence in almost any computing field means that it is indeed an essential skill set if you intend to become a developer.

Objective-C

Being the language of the iPhone SDK, it is important to learn if you need to build applications for the iPhone. While you can build applications for the iPhone in C++ it is a rather more complicated process than using Objective-C.

Your skillset in Objective-C will not go to waste, since it can also be used for developing applications for Mac OSX and even PCs. However Apple has very vague policies regarding which applications will be accepted in the Apple store, so it is important you keep their terms in consideration.

C++ for S60

The language of choice for Symbian, Nokia's preferred platform. The dialect of C++ used by Symbian differs from the standard, and is supposed to be tougher. While Symbian usage in mobile phones is decreasing, it is still the operating system on many mobile phones out there and will continue to be the OS for Nokia devices for the foreseeable future. Nokia will also make Symbian open source soon, which might affect its popularity for the better.

Developing... my career?

It is very possible to make a career out of programming, but if you intend to, it is important that you get into it as soon as possible. Leave nothing unexplored, and go where your curiosity takes you. Experiment. It is the best way to explore any programming language, and is more important than reading any book or taking up any course.

Any certification that you intend to get for proving your programming skill is not as important as the unique perspective you bring to programming. There is no dearth of code monkeys swinging on the branches of multiple certifications.

If you are indeed passionate about programming, you will find that there are plenty of opportunities. Think about it, programming is something that gazillions of open source developers find rewarding enough to do for free!

Here's to a brilliant career in development ahead of you, and hoping we'll get free licences to any software you write! 